He talked as he played, however (perhaps without knowing it), and constantly reasoned out what he thought I was doing. I caught on and started doing what he thought I was doing, and in the third game I managed to elicit a draw.

Pauline Bloom was also at that Hydra Club session. She was the person who had invited me to join the Brooklyn Authors Club seven years before and through whom, therefore, I had indirectly met Gertrude.

As for remarriages, we got a Christmas card from Bob Heinlein later in the month. It was signed Bob and Ginny. It seems he had married Virginia Gershtenfeld, who had been at the Navy Yard with us as a WAVE.

The January 1949 Astounding appeared with 'The Red Queen's Race" 2 included.

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The year 1948 was still another poor writing year. I had sold two stories and had had one anthologization sale, and my total earnings from writing came to $640. From 1944 on, each year had seen me earn less from writing than the year before.

Of course, 1948 was better than 1947 in that I had a paying job. I had earned $2,625 working for Elderfield in 1948 so that my total income was roughly $3,300. It was about my Navy Yard income, which certainly represented no progress in four years, considering that prices had gone higher in the aftermath of the war.

2 3 On January 2, 1949, I celebrated my twenty-ninth birthday, which

1 found rather upsetting on two counts. It was, for one thing, the last year of my twenties and there was the unavoidable thought that in one year I would be thirty. That was no age, surely, for a child prodigy like myself. In fact, so drearily was I aware of my advanced state of chronological decay that, for the first time, the thought of an autobiography occurred to me.

Second, despite my advanced age I had not yet settled down and

2 See The Early Asimoy.

found my life's work. For the fifth time in a row I had celebrated my birthday in a new dwelling place and in each case the place was clearly a temporary one. How long would that continue?